

SPORTS

■ 10 Biggest Controversies

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Boxing legend Muhammad Ali once said, "Champions are made from something they have deep inside them—a desire, a dream, a vision." Leander Paes's power play got India its first individual Olympic medal in 44 years in 1996. A bunch of Young Turks got India the T20 World Cup, an achievement at par with the 1983 World Cup win of Kapil's Devils. But desires, dreams and vision have never been enough for Indian sportsmen. They have had to fight with their sports authorities for their rights and overcome an in-built disdain for sporting achievement in our society. That is why Sushil Kumar's bronze astonished many. That is why, when he spoke of modern technical inputs and financial support for wrestlers, people sat up and took notice. The sorry state of affairs in badminton provoked India's greatest, and most gentlemanly, player of the game to protest. The government ignored many deserving stars for the Arjuna Award and no one but Milkha Singh spoke up. K.P.S. Gill was allowed a free hand in the Indian Hockey Federation (IHF), the result of which was that in 2008, the team failed to even qualify for the Olympics, a first since 1928. Clearly, it takes a lot to be a sportsman in India, leave alone a champion.

10

biggest controversies

An ageing warhorse sacks half a hockey team. The length of a skirt makes a group of Muslim hardliners see red and issue a fatwa against Sania Mirza. A leaked e-mail leads to a clash of two cricket titans. In India, sports is often a different ball game.

1 Scoring a Duck Cricketers vs BCCI



The BCCI has never been a novice when it comes to controversies. Even in 1989, six cricketers—Dilip Vengsarkar, Kapil Dev, Ravi Shastri, Arun Lal, Kiran More and Mohammad Azharuddin—took it to court over contracts. In October 1989, *INDIA TODAY* reported, "The showdown has caused a new rethinking on the board's structure."